I'm Not Giving My Black Back!

By Jewel Diamond Taylor

INTRODUCTION

A common belief about Black women is that they are triply disadvantaged due to their gender, their ethnicity, and their poverty. An alternative perspective on Black women portrays them as strong, resilient, and adaptive in their ability to cope with adversity, support their families, and develop avenues of self-esteem and self-actualization. Ironically, both views reflect the realities of Black women's experience in America. On the one hand, they have been victims of discrimination, economic exploitation, and social rejection for over 370 years. On the other hand, they have overcome many of these barriers through developing a set of cultural attitudes, a pattern of coping strategies, and a series of help-seeking behaviors which have enabled them to survive and sometimes thrive in a frequently hostile, exploitive, and unsupportive environment. Jewel Diamond Taylor speaks in the collective voice of resilient black women throughout the nation in "I'm Not Giving My Black Back!"

I'm Not Giving My Black Back! I'm not giving up my greens or my grits or saying "girl" and putting

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my hands on my hips. You see... Life for me ain't been no crystal stair and I'm not giving up Rosa Parks, Fannie Lou Hamer, Mary McCleod Bethune, Sojourner Truth, Madame C J. Walker, Toni Morrison or Dr. Maya Angelou, 'cause you see, I am a phenomenal woman and I'm not giving my black back.

I'm not giving up my crown, waves, braids, curls, locks, kinks, scarves or Muslim garb. I'm not giving up sitting in Ma's kitchen eating peach cobbler or sweet potato pie and hearing her ask me, "How you doing baby"? I'm not giving up going to "You Buy, We Fry" on Fridays, or bar-b-ques on Saturday playing bid whist and slammin' those dominoes. I'm not giving back Harriet Tubman's train, Soul Train, Coltrane or the midnight train to Georgia.

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Now, you can meet me at the function, at the junction but I still won't give up B.B. King, the Whispers, Fancy Ms. Nancy, Lena Horne, the Philadelphia Sound, Motown or the Temptations. 'Cause you see, it's the way we do the things we do, like building the pyramids that still stand made by our forefathers' hands where the diamonds, oil, silver and gold are buried in our rich dark land.

I'm not giving my black back! I'm happy being nappy with my wide hips and my wide nose and the rich melanin in my skin. I love putting lotion on my ashy legs. Oh, I'm happy being nappy and being in the skin that I'm in. I won't deny or forget my ancestors who lay in a wet grave at the

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bottom of the sea in the middle passage from slave trade.

And I won't give up on our youth of today who still need a way made. I won't give back Miles even though he didn't smile. I won't give back Marvin Gaye, Richard Pryor, Phyllis Hyman, Billie Holiday or Billy Eckstein, Jackie Robinson or Jackie Wilson. I won't give back the electric slide, Alvin Ailey, Bojangles or Debbie Allen. You think I'd give up reading my Jet, Ebony, Essence, Emerge, Black Enterprise, Heart and Soul or Upscale magazines?

For we are a colorful people. Like Curtis Mayfield sang, we are a people that are "darker than blue. " We are honey, cinnamon, mahogany and chocolate. We are

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REDD Fox, James BROWN, Barry WHITE,
The Mothers of the Church dressed in
WHITE, The Color PURPLE, the Lady Who
Sings the BLUES and we are Al GREEN
with love and happiness.

Oh, NO... I'm not giving my black back!
I'm not giving back Maxine (Waters),
Martin, Medgar, Malcolm, Mandela,
Marley, Marcus, Muhammad Ali,
Michael (Jordan) or the Million Man
March. I'm not giving my black back!
Lift up the black woman's spirit.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jewel Diamond Taylor
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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

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